

Europe's original deep dark wood

Germany's Bavarian Forest National Park and the Czech Republic's Bohemian forest combine to form the largest area of forest remaining in central Europe. The forest cloaks rolling mountains that, despite being relatively low, constitute a continental divide from which the headwaters of the Danube, Vltava, and Elbe rivers drain in different directions. The mountains, gentle hills, curved valleys, and pockets of hard granite rock are evidence of a land carved by glaciers during the last ice age.

Ancient woodland

Much of the Bavarian forest is old-growth and undisturbed by humans, and conservation work in Germany's first national park aims to keep it untouched. Its plants and animals include several ice age relict species, such as the boreal owl, three-toed woodpecker, Norwegian wolf spider, and quillwort, a scarce semiaquatic fern.

The Bavarian forest has acidic soil and water. This is partly due to its cool, wet climate, but also to the overwhelming dominance of trees such as spruce, fir, and beech, which form closed canopies that block sunlight and warmth. These conditions limit opportunities for ground plants and some insect species to thrive, but fungi, mosses, and invertebrates associated with dead wood abound. Indeed, the forest boasts more than 1,300 species of mushroom, bracket fungus, and puffball. The ancient forest is also home to several large animals, including brown bears, gray wolves, lynxes, wild cats, roe deer, wild boar, capercaillies, and eagle owls.



CLEVER COMPETITOR

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The porcelain fungus is a beechwood specialist. Its pale fruiting bodies appear in fall on dead wood, into which it secretes a chemical known as strobilurin. This inhibits the growth of other fungi, thus reducing competition.

DORMOUSE DUO

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Two native dormice share
the forest, using different
zones to avoid competition.
The tiny, golden-furred hazel
dormouse favors a complex
matrix of low shrubs, while
the much larger, silver gray
edible dormouse lives
in the forest canopy



HAZEL DORMOUSE

LINKED FORTUNES
The cyclic boom and bust of roe deer populations has a dramatic effect on the reintroduced Eurasian lynx. Severe winters reduce deer numbers so the lynx lose out to the larger wolves, which work cooperatively to drive out competitors.



EURASIAN LYNX

95% forest cover

3,693 invertebrate

Germany's first national
PORCELAIN FUNGUS